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3848 Brighton Court
Alexandria, VA 22305

July 27, 1982

Inspector General
Department of the Army
Attention: FOIA Coordinator
The Pentagon
Washington, DC 20310

Dear Sir:

Under terms of the U. S. Freedom of Information Act, I hereby request that you furnish me a copy of all U. S. Army records relating to the widely publicized Cash-Landrum incident of December 29, 1980, near Dayton, Texas, in which figured a flight of military helicopters.

It is assumed that these records include both printed material and radio/video recordings of interviews; that they contain the incident's entire investigative case file developed by your investigator Lt. Col. George Sarran, USA; that they reveal the identity, mission purpose, and post-flight accounts of the helicopter crews involved; that they include all Serious Incident Reports (SIR) on the extent of any military operations associated with the incident; and that they include all records on the incident produced by the Army's Assistant Chief of Staff for Intelligence.

Yours sincerely,

Frederic L. Whiting

Copy furnished to:

Chairman, Subcommittee on Government Information and Individual Rights, U. S. House of Representatives

DEPARTMENT OF THE ARMY
OFFICE OF THE INSPECTOR GENERAL
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20310

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REPLY TO ATTENTION OF:

DAIG-ZXF

19 AUG 1982

Mr. Frederic L. Whiting
3848 Brighton Court
Alexandria, VA 22305

Dear Mr. Whiting:

This responds to your letter of 27 July 1982 requesting a copy of a report of investigation. Your request was received in this office for reply on 6 August 1982.

Inspector general records are closely protected and controlled in order that the inspector general may effectively fulfill his responsibility as the confidential representative of his commander. It is my position that the records you have requested are exempt from mandatory release under the Freedom of Information Act, 5 USC 552(b)(5), (6) and (7) and paragraphs 2-12e, f and g, AR 340-17; however, I have considered your request and, as the Initial Denial Authority, have decided to furnish you the records with the following exceptions:

a. Certain portions of the report that contain the opinions, conclusions and recommendations of the officer conducting the investigation. This material is considered to be intra-agency memoranda and, as such, is exempt from mandatory release under the Freedom of Information Act, 5 USC 552(b)(5) and (7) and paragraphs 2-12e and g, AR 340-17. In order for an inspector general to serve his commander effectively, he must be able to communicate frankly and fully without concern for public disclosure.

b. Certain portions which contain material concerning other individuals, the release of which would be considered an unwarranted invasion of the individuals' privacy. This material is exempt from mandatory release under the Freedom of Information Act, 5 USC 552(b)(6) and (7) and paragraphs 2-12f and g, AR 340-17.

c. Certain portions of the record did not originate within the U.S. Army inspector general system of records. These documents have been referred to the US Air Force inspector general, in accordance with Army Regulation 340-17. If you desire to appeal this initial denial, you should submit your appeal through this office to the Secretary of the Army, ATTN: General Counsel, Washington, DC 20310.

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DAIG-ZXF
Mr. Frederic L. Whiting

The releasable portions of the records are inclosed. The fees chargeable for search and reproduction of this material are hereby waived.

Sincerely,

Richard G. Trefry

RICHARD G. TREFRY
Lieutenant General, USA
The Inspector General

1 Incl
As stated

Dear Mr. Wyden:

This is in final response to your 16 February 1982 request to the Assistant Secretary of Defense for information concerning possible military involvement in an alleged UFO incident that occurred 29 December 1980 near the town of Dayton, Texas. An inspector general inquiry has been completed.

The allegation that Army, Army National Guard, or Army Reserve helicopters might have been involved on the evening of 29 December 1980 is not substantiated. Agencies queried included major Army commands, Army installations, test and evaluation agencies, National Guard and Reserve flying detachments, the Houston police helicopter unit, and others. Interviews were conducted with the victims and other persons thought to have information concerning the incident.

There was no evidence developed which supported the contention that Army helicopters were involved.

Sincerely,

Honorable Ron Wyden
House of Representatives
Washington, DC 20515

DAIG-AC

MEMORANDUM FOR DIVISION CHIEF

The allegation that Army, National Guard, or Army Reserve helicopters might have been involved in a UFO incident that occurred 29 December 1980 [redacted]

DISCUSSION:

This case was given to Army Congressional Liaison by AF Congressional Liaison after the AF could not determine any involvement. The three victims (two women and a young boy) clearly recall viewing some 23 helicopters orbiting around the object. Through the process of identifying silhouettes, some of the helicopters were determined to be twin rotors, or CH47s (Chinooks). Since the Army has the preponderance of troop and heavy equipment helicopters, the case was transferred to the DAIG for inquiry.

The DAIG inquiry focused exclusively on the question whether Army, Army National Guard or Army Reserve helicopters were involved in this incident. There was no effort to substantiate the existence of unidentified flying objects (UFOs), the events that happened that evening, or the medical problems that allegedly have occurred to the three victims.

Prior to visiting the site area, numerous phone calls were made to the different Army commands to request that records be checked to determine if any helicopters were flying at the approximate time and location of the reported incident. It is noted that the site of the incident is some 35 miles northeast of Houston, Texas, near Dayton, Texas. The reported time and date were between 2100 hrs and 2130 hrs, 29 December 1980 (Monday). There were no scheduled maneuvers in the area, and most Army units traditionally observe very limited operations on half day schedules.

Requests for assistance for any pertinent information were made to FORSCOM, Operation and Reserve Training Division, and program director for new systems; TRADOC, Operations and Training; Aviation Command, project manager for aviation systems; DARCOM-IG; TECOM; OTEA; DCSRDA; Fort Hood-IG; TCATA (at Fort Hood), and the Corpus Christi repair facility. Coordination was made with John Schussler, project director for manned flight operations with NASA, Major Dennis Haire local commander for eight Chinook Texas National Guard helicopters stationed at Ellington AFB, south of Houston; and CW4 Gustofson, senior AST for seven Army Reserve huey helicopters stationed at Tomball civilian airfield, northwest of Houston. Other coordination was made with Dr. Rank, M.D., Radiologist; and Dr. Niemtzow, M.D., USAF, Radiation Oncologist (specializing in radiation for cancer patients); both of whom had interest and knowledge in the case. After a period of time to thoroughly check flight records, all reports concerning any known helicopters flying in that general area were negative. 31 Mar

A trip was then made to the Texas site area to interview people with pertinent knowledge. John Schussler was interviewed. He had followed the case since February 1981 and was thoroughly conversant with all aspects of the case. Vicki Landrum (older of two women victims) was interviewed. She testified as

to the events that evening. She was adamant that she and the other two victims (Betty Cash and her grandson) had counted approximately 23 helicopters flying around the object shortly after the object had ascended back in the sky. She related the medical disorders that have happened to each of the three victims; including sores on skin, hair falling out, blackened fingernails, constant diarrhea, loss of appetite, and diminished eyesight. The medical evidence of deterioration of health seems almost irrefutable, but was not a primary consideration in the DAIG inquiry.

Ms. Landrum related an experience she had in May 1981, some 5 months after the alleged incident. An Army National Guard helicopter (CH47) from Ellington AFB landed in the Dayton town square to be on static display for a local celebration. In a conversation with the aircraft pilot, CW3 Culberson, Mrs. Landrum heard him to say that he was flying the evening of the incident in response to an emergency by the Montgomery County Sherriff's Department. When pressed for more details, the pilot responded that he was prohibited from adding more information because of national security. After the interview with Ms. Landrum the DAIG investigator telephoned Ms. Betty Case in Alabama to corroborate or add any knowledge to the incident supplied by Ms. Landrum. Ms. Cash had moved to Alabama some months earlier so that her mother could take care of her because of the continued deterioration of her health allegedly caused by the incident. The 8 year old boy was not interviewed.

Next, a local Dayton policeman and his wife were interviewed. He recalled a conversation that he had with his wife at approximately 0040 hours, 30 December 1981, some 3 hours after the alleged sighting by the three victims, as they were returning from a visit to her parents' home. Some 8 miles from Dayton and within 5 miles of the earlier sighting, the policeman and his wife heard loud noises and noticed helicopters flying in groups of three in a "V" formation. They vividly remember discussing that some maneuvers must be going on nearby, the lateness of the hour (sometime between 0030 hrs and 0100 hrs), the helicopters were flying lower than normal (400 or 500 feet from ground level), they were twin rotors, and some of the helicopters periodically would turn on spotlights or landing lights which indicated they might be looking for something. Although the policeman discussed his experience with others at the office the next day neither he nor his wife could give any other names of people who might also have seen helicopters that evening.

A trip was made to Conroe, TX to interview the local sheriff. Neither he, his deputies, nor the dispatcher on duty the night in question could recall any emergency or any reason why helicopters might have been requested or flying.

Chief Warrant Officer Culberson, full time employee and maintenance officer for eight Texas National Guard helicopters at Ellington AFB stated that he remembers talking to Ms. Landrum while his aircraft was on static display in Dayton, TX. However, he emphatically stated that he was not flying that evening, he knows of no one who was flying, and his response to Ms. Landrum was simply that he had heard on the media that some helicopters responded to a request for assistance by the Montgomery County Sheriff's Department.

Major Haire, the National Guard detachment commander and CW3 Culberson's CO, stated that none of his aircraft were flying that evening. He further stated that it would be most unusual for any flying on a Monday evening. Virtually all flying in the unit is done on week-ends with occasional make-up flying done on Thursday evenings. Also, all flight missions must have his approval before the flight.

An interview was conducted with CW4 Gustofson, the senior full time administrator for the seven Army Reserve huey helicopters located at Tonball Airfield on the northern edge of Houston. He stated that none of his helicopters were flying that evening. He further stated that six of his seven helicopters had large painted red and white crosses which would have been clearly visible from the ground, even during reasonable darkness. He stated that if any of his helicopters were flying that evening, he would necessarily have been involved.

Additional inquiries were made to the captain of the Houston Police Department in charge of helicopter operations, the local FAA spokesman, and the civilian helicopter repair facility at Montgomery County Airport. No one had any knowledge of helicopters flying in the area.

Mr. John Schussler stated that another person had earlier told him that he saw helicopters flying at the approximate time of the incident. However, that person refused to be interviewed or otherwise cooperate in the inquiry.

Upon returning to Washington, DC, requests for information were made to the IG at the JFK Center, Special Operations, AF and Navy IGs, CIA, and the Bergstrom AFB JAG. In response to letters from Senators Tower, Bentsen, and Congressman Wilson, representatives of the JAG at Bergstrom AFB interviewed the two ladies and the boy in August 1981. The results of the interview were provided this office. Although the apparent purpose of the interview was to submit a claim against the government, the JAG office at Bergstrom AFB presently knows of no claim submitted by the victims or their lawyer. In summary, no one could provide pertinent information that might involve Army helicopters.

GENERAL COMMENT

Ms. Landrum and Ms. Cash were credible. The DAIG investigator felt [redacted] The policeman and his wife were also credible witnesses. There was no perception that anyone was trying to exaggerate the truth. All interviewees were extremely cooperative and eager to be helpful in any manner. Through the course of inquiry the DAIG investigating officer tried to concentrate on any reason or anyone or organization which might have been flying helicopters that particular evening in that general area. There was no evidence presented that would indicate that Army, National Guard, or Army Reserve helicopters were involved.

GEORGE C. SARRAN
Lieutenant Colonel, IG
Assistance Division